

## Chapter 1

. The Mystical  
Way The Way  
that can be  
described is not  
the absolute  
Way; the name  
that can be given  
is not the  
absolute name.  
Nameless it is  
the source of  
heaven and  
earth; named it is  
the mother of all  
things. Whoever  
is desireless, see

The Ineffable,  
about which is  
spoken, is not the  
eternal Ineffable A  
name for the  
Unnameable, is  
but a name The  
Unnameable is  
what makes  
everything what it  
is By naming  
things you divide  
the Indivisible Only  
one who gives up  
all his desires can  
experience the I

s the essence of  
life. Whoever  
desires, sees its  
manifestations.  
These two are  
the same, but  
what is produced  
has names. They  
both may be  
called the cosmic  
mystery: from the  
cosmic to the  
mystical is the  
door to the  
essence of all  
life. up

ndivisible One who  
still cherishes  
desires, will  
experience only  
dissension Both  
will see the same  
reality, but  
experience it  
differently One  
who goes from the  
false reality into  
the other, Will  
pass through the  
narrow gate and  
receive the secret  
of true life up

## Chapter 2

. Relativity and Not Interfering When the people of the world all know beauty as beauty, there arises the recognition of ugliness. When they all know the good as good, there arises the recognition of bad. Therefore being and non-being produce each other; difficult and easy complete each other; long and short contrast each other; high and low distinguish each other; sound and voice harmonize with

each other; beginning and end follow each other. Therefore the wise manage affairs without interfering and teach beyond the words. All things rise, and they do not turn away from them. They give them life, but do not take possession of them. They act, but do not rely on their own ability. They accomplish, but claim no credit. Because they claim no credit, their accomplishment remains with them. up

When people think `this´ is beautiful, they must think `that´ is ugly When people say `this´ is good, than they have to say `that´ is evil This is Inevitable People create a false reality out of the real one Hard and easy are relative Long and short depend upon each other High and low are determined

by a position Sound and voice need one another Before and beyond assume a point of view That's why a wise man acts without intentions And won't decide for others what to do He'll let anything happen as it happens He won't consider what he does as his own merit And only therein is he praiseworthy up

## Chapter 3

. Simplicity Do not exalt the worthy, so that people will not compete. Do not value rare treasure, so that people will not steal. Do not display objects of desire, so that people's hearts will not be disturbed. Therefore the wise lead by keeping t

When you praise people for their achievements, people will compete When you call things valuable, people will steal When people flaunt desirable things, it will make other people restless Therefore the sage sets himself to the task of emptying their heads To m

heir hearts pure, their bellies full, their ambitions weak, and their bones strong, so that the people may be purified of their thoughts and desires; and the cunning ones will not interfere. By acting without interfering, all may live in peace. up

ake sure they're not hungry, discourage their ambitions and strengthen their bodies So people will be without anxiety and without the desire for knowledge And the scientists will be played off the field When people won't labour anymore All will live in peace up

## Chapter 4

. The Infinite  
Way The Way is  
infinite; its use is  
never exhausted.  
It is bottomless,  
like the  
fountainhead of  
all things. It  
smoothes its  
roughness; it  
untie

Nature contains  
nothing but  
natures; and  
these natures  
are nothing over  
and above  
Nature. In  
Nature, all  
natures originate,  
all conflicts are  
settled, all  
differences are  
united, all disturb

That which  
maintains the  
Creation Is like  
an empty barrel  
that's  
inexhaustible It is  
like a fathomless  
emptiness, filling  
the whole  
Creation Its  
sharpness brings  
about curves Its  
angles di

s its tangles. It  
softens its light; it  
calms its turmoil.  
Deep and still,  
ever present. I  
do not know its  
source. It seems  
to have existed  
before the Lord.  
up

ances are  
quieted. Yet no  
matter how many  
natures come  
into being, they  
can never  
exhaust Nature.  
To look for an  
external source  
of Nature is  
foolish, for  
Nature is the  
source of all  
else. up

ssolve It dims its  
light It restrains  
its touch How  
pure and calm it  
stays, like deep  
waters I don't  
know its origin It  
seems like it is  
even older than  
that by which it is  
brought forth up

## Chapter 5

. Emptiness and the Center  
Nature is not humane. It treats all things like sacrificial objects. The wise are not humane. They regard people like sacrificial objects. How the universe

Opposites are not sympathetic to each other. Each one of the many kinds of opposites acts as if it could get along without its other. But Nature treats opposites impartially, dealing with each of every pair of opposites with the same indifference. And the intelligent man will regard opposites in the same manner. No matter how deeply natures are torn by opposition, Nature itself remains unchanged. In conflict

The Creation does not pretend to be friendly. It treats all things impartially. One who is wise doesn't act friendly. All people are equal to him. The Universe is like bellows. Although

niverse is like a bellows! While empty, it is never exhausted. The more it is worked, the more it produces. Much talk brings exhaustion. It is better to keep to the center. up

h empty, it fills continuously. The harder it works, the more it brings forth. The more you talk about it, the wearier you get. Therefore, you'd better stick to what really matters. up

## Chapter 6

. The Mystical  
Female The spirit  
of the valley  
never dies. It is  
called the  
mystical female.  
The door of the  
mystic

The tendency  
towards  
opposition is  
ever-present.  
Opposition is the  
source of all  
growth. And the  
principle of  
opposition is the  
source of all opp

The spirit of  
depth never dies  
People  
sometimes call it  
the Great Mother  
The gate through  
which she  
breathes

al female is the  
root of heaven  
and earth. It  
seems to be  
continuously  
within us. Use it,  
and it will never  
fail. up

osites. The  
principle of  
opposition is  
inherent in  
Nature, so  
oppositeness will  
continue forever,  
no matter how  
many opposites  
may come and  
go. up

Is the foundation  
of Creation It  
appears to be  
everlasting When  
you rely on that,  
life will be  
effortless up

## Chapter 7

. Enduring  
Heaven is  
eternal, and the  
earth is very old.  
They can be  
eternal and long  
lasting, because  
they do not exist  
for themselves,  
and for this  
reason can long  
endure.  
Therefore the  
wise put t

The principle of  
initiation persists;  
and the principle  
of completion  
continues. Why  
do such  
opposing  
principles  
persist? Because  
they inhere in  
Nature, rather  
than stand by  
themselves. That  
is why opposites  
endure. The  
intellig

The Universe is  
everlasting The  
reason why it is  
everlasting Is  
because it  
doesn't exist for  
itself Therefore it  
can last  
Therefore a wise  
man behaves as  
the least

hemselves last,  
but find  
themselves  
foremost. They  
are indifferent to  
themselves, and  
yet they always  
remain. Is it not  
because they do  
not live for  
themselves that  
they find  
themselves  
fulfilled? up

ent man, when  
an issue arises,  
stands off and  
observes both  
contentions.  
Since he does  
not take sides,  
he never loses a  
battle. By not  
favouring one  
side more than  
the other, he is  
able to  
appreciate the  
virtues of both  
sides. up

And because he  
is least, he is the  
greatest He is  
detached and  
therefore he is  
safe Couldn't it  
be possible that  
he is perfect,  
Just because he  
is disinterested?  
up

## Chapter 8

. The Best Are  
Like Water The  
best are like water.  
Water benefits all  
things and does  
not compete with  
them. It flows to  
the lowest level. In  
this it comes near  
to the Way. In their  
dwellings, they  
love the earth. In  
their hearts, they  
love what is prof

A perfect human  
being is like the  
water That  
benefits all things  
and competes  
with nothing It  
stays in places  
which others  
despise But in  
this way it follows  
its origin In his  
heart the wise  
cherishes  
simplicity In  
conta

ound. In their  
friendship, they  
love humanity. In  
their words, they  
love sincerity. In  
government, they  
love peace. In  
business, they  
love ability. In their  
actions, they love  
timeliness. It is  
because they do  
not compete that  
there is no  
resentment. up

ct with others he  
is amiable In his  
words he is  
reliable In his  
leading he is  
peaceful In what  
he does he is  
competent He  
does everything  
at the moment it  
needs to be done  
He won't fight  
And therefore he  
is impeccable up



## Chapter 9

### Moderation

Stretch a bow to  
the very full, and  
you will wish you  
had stopped in  
time. Temper a  
sword-edge to its  
very sharpest,  
and the edge will  
not last long.  
When gold and  
jade fi

### Going to

extremes is  
never best. For if  
you make a  
blade too sharp,  
it will become  
dull too quickly  
And if you hoard  
all the wealth,  
you are bound to  
be attacked. If  
you become  
proud and  
arrogant  
regarding

### It is better to

carry an empty  
barrel than a full  
one Sharpen a  
knife until it is  
razor-sharp and  
it won't last long  
When a house is  
filled with  
valuables, it is  
imp

If your hall, you  
will not be able to  
keep them safe.  
To be proud with  
honor and wealth  
is to cause one's  
own downfall.  
Withdraw as  
soon as your  
work is done.  
Such is heaven's  
way. up

your good  
fortune, you will  
naturally beget  
enemies who  
jealously despise  
you. The way to  
success is this:  
having achieved  
your goal, be  
satisfied not to  
go further. For  
this is the way  
Nature operates.  
up

ossible to guard  
When wealth and  
ambition make  
one arrogant, it  
will lead to a fall  
When fame and  
success menace  
you, pull back  
That's the only  
road to true bliss  
up

## Chapter 10

### Mystical Power

Can you embrace  
the One with your  
soul, and never  
depart from the  
Way? Can you  
concentrate your  
vital force to  
achieve the  
gentleness of a  
new-born baby?  
Can you cleanse  
and purify your  
mystic vision until  
it is clear? Can  
you love the  
people and govern  
the state without  
interfering?

Can you empty  
your head and  
lastingly lose  
yourself in  
Creation? Can you  
live up to your  
nature and  
become like a  
child? Can you  
purify the doors of  
perception and  
see clearly again?  
Can you love your  
fellow man and  
serve mankind  
disinterestedly?  
Can you go in and  
out of the narrow  
gate without any  
effort? Can you be  
in the world  
without be

Can you play the  
role of the female  
in opening and  
closing the doors  
of heaven? Can  
you understand all  
and penetrate all  
without using the  
mind? To give  
birth and to  
nourish, to give  
birth without taking  
possession, to act  
without obligation,  
to lead without  
dominating--- this  
is mystical power.  
up

ing possessed by  
it? Can you realize  
that you can't  
know anything and  
therefore  
understand  
everything? Nature  
brings forth  
everything and  
feeds everything  
She brings forth  
but possesses  
nothing She does  
everything  
disinterestedly and  
asks for nothing  
She leads but  
demands nothing  
That is what  
people call the inc  
omprehensibility of  
Nature up

## Chapter 11

. Use What Does Not Exist Thirty spokes are united around the hub of a wheel, but the usefulness of the wheel depends on the space where nothing exists. Clay is molded into a vessel, but the usefulness of the vessel depends on the

Every positive involves its negative or opposing factor; for example: In order to turn a wheel, although thirty spokes must revolve, the axle must remain motionless; so both the moving and the non-moving are needed to produce revolution. In order to mold a vase, although one must use clay, he must also provide a hollow space of empty clay; s

Thirty spokes unite within the nave But the wheel is only useful because of the cavity inside the nave Clay is kneaded into vases But the utility is determined by the cavity When building a hou

space where nothing exists. Doors and windows are cut out of the walls of a house, and the usefulness of the house depends on the space where nothing exists. Therefore take advantage of what exists, and use what does not exist. up

o both clay and the absence of clay are required to produce a vessel. In order to build a house, although we must establish solid walls, we must also provide doors and windows; so both the impenetrable and penetrable are essential to a useful building. Therefore, we profit equally by the positive and negative ingredients in each situation. up

se they leave blank spots in the walls for doors and windows But the utility of the house depends on the cavity inside Therefore, that which exists is useful But the cavity makes it possible up

## Chapter 12

. Satisfy the  
Inner Self The  
five colors blind  
the eyes; the five  
musical tones  
deafen the ears;  
the five flavors  
dull the taste.  
Racing and  
hunting madden  
the mind

Interest in the  
varieties of colour  
diverts the eye  
from regarding the  
thing which is  
coloured. Attention  
to the differences  
between sounds  
distracts the ear  
from consideration  
for the source of  
the sounds. Desire  
for enjoyment of  
the various  
flavours misdirects  
the appetite from  
seeking foods  
which are truly  
nourishing. E

All those artificial  
colours blind  
people's eyes All  
that man-made  
music deafens  
people's ears All  
those various  
flavours dull our  
taste Horse  
races and  
hunting drive  
people crazy The  
desire for scarce

nd. Precious  
goods keep their  
owners on guard.  
Therefore the  
wise satisfy the  
inner self rather  
than external  
senses. They  
accept the one  
and reject the  
other. up

cessive devotion  
to chasing about  
and pursuing  
things agitates the  
mind with insane  
excitement. Greed  
for riches  
ensnares one's  
efforts to pursue  
his healthier  
motives. The  
intelligent man is  
concerned about  
his genuine needs  
and avoids being  
confused by  
dazzling  
appearances. He  
wisely  
distinguishes one  
from the other. up

goods Hinders  
people from  
going on the  
straight and  
simple path  
Therefore the  
wise finds his  
satisfaction In  
feeding himself  
and then he  
won't exhaust his  
eyes Therefore  
he does this and  
leaves that up

## Chapter 13

. Selflessness  
Good fortune and  
misfortune cause  
apprehension.  
Regard great  
trouble as you  
regard your self.  
What is meant by  
"Good fortune and  
misfortune cause  
apprehension?"  
Those with good  
fortune are  
apprehensive of  
their gain. Those  
with misfortune are  
apprehensive of  
their loss. What is  
meant

Watch out for  
gratitude and  
criticism Honour  
and misfortune are  
as disastrous as  
having character  
What does that  
say? Watch out for  
gratitude and  
criticism? Watch  
out for gratitude,  
because it  
originates from  
submission Watch  
out for criticism,  
because it comes  
from superior  
power Therefore,  
watch out for  
gratitude and  
criticism What  
does it mean that  
honour and misfort

by "Regard great  
trouble as you  
regard your self?"  
Great trouble  
comes from being  
selfish. Being  
selfless, what  
trouble is there?  
Therefore those  
who value the  
world as  
themselves may  
be entrusted to  
govern the world.  
Those who love  
the world as  
themselves may  
be entrusted to  
care for the world.  
up

une are as bad as  
having character?  
Disasters come  
over us because  
we've got  
something to lose  
If we had nothing  
to lose, which  
disasters could still  
strike us?  
Therefore: to him  
who considers  
himself just as  
worthy as the  
world, Mankind  
can entrust the  
world And to him  
who loves himself  
and the world just  
as unconditionally,  
Mankind can  
entrust the care for  
the world up

## Chapter 14

. The Formless  
Way We look at it,  
and do not see it; it  
is invisible. We  
listen to it, and do  
not hear it; it is  
inaudible. We  
touch it, and do  
not feel it; it is  
intangible. These  
three elude our  
inquiries, and  
hence merge into  
one. Not by its  
rising, is it bright,  
nor by its sinking,  
is it dark. Infinite  
and eternal, it  
cann

We look at it but  
we do not see it  
and we call it the  
invisible We listen  
to it but don't hear  
it and we call it the  
inaudible We  
grope at it but  
never touch it and  
we call it the  
untouchable The  
invisible, the  
inaudible and the  
untouchable come  
together in one  
There is no light  
when it rises There  
is no darkness  
when it descends  
Continuously,  
constantly, but it  
cannot

ot be defined. It  
returns to  
nothingness. This  
is the form of the  
formless, being in  
non-being. It is  
nebulous and  
elusive. Meet it,  
and you do not  
see its beginning.  
Follow it, and you  
do not see its end.  
Stay with the  
ancient Way in  
order to master  
what is present.  
Knowing the  
primeval beginning  
is the essence of  
the Way. up

be put into words  
And it returns to  
nothing This is  
what they call the  
form of the  
formless, the  
image of the  
invisible People  
call it indefinite  
and impalpable  
You won't see it  
from the front You  
won't see it from  
behind One who  
lives after their  
original  
conscience, lives  
in the present And  
understands  
everything that has  
ever been That is  
living according to  
nature up

## Chapter 15

. The Wise The  
wise have ancient  
mystic wisdom and  
profound  
understanding, too  
deep to  
comprehend.  
Because they can  
not be  
comprehended,  
they can only be  
described by  
analogy: cautious,  
like crossing a  
stream in winter;  
alert, like one  
aware of danger  
on all sides;  
courteous, like a  
visiting guest;  
self-effacing, like  
ice beginning to  
melt; genuine, like  
a piece of

uncarved wood;  
open and  
receptive, like a  
valley; freely  
mixing, like muddy  
water. Who can  
make sense of a  
muddy world? Let  
it be still, and it  
becomes clear.  
Who can remain  
calm, and through  
activity come back  
to life? Those who  
embrace this Way  
do not over-extend  
themselves.  
Because they do  
not over-extend  
themselves, they  
do not wear out  
and are not  
replaced. up

The wise of old  
were profound and  
acute People  
thought of them as  
unfathomable  
Because they  
where  
unfathomable, I'll  
try to sketch their  
way of living: They  
seemed cautious,  
like people who  
cross a wintry river  
They seemed  
irresolute, as if  
danger was  
threatening  
everywhere They  
seemed dignified,  
as if they where  
guests They  
seemed natural,  
like raw wood  
They seemed  
empty,

like a valley They  
seemed opaque,  
like muddy water  
How can one  
make muddy water  
clear? Stagnation  
will settle the mud  
down and the  
water will become  
clear Let  
everything happen  
as it happens and  
you will come to  
rest The head of  
the wise is empty,  
he does not  
search for  
anything and  
expects nothing  
He is empty,  
everlasting,  
youthful and not  
caught in time He  
is perfect up

## Chapter 16

. Know the Eternal  
Empty yourself of  
everything.  
Maintain a steady  
serenity. All things  
take shape and  
become active, but  
I see them return  
to their source, like  
vegetation that  
grows and  
flourishes, but  
returns to the root  
from which it  
springs. Returning  
to the source is  
serenity; it is to  
realize one's  
destiny. To realize  
one's destiny is to  
know the eternal.  
To know the  
eternal is to be  
enlightene

One who has an  
empty head is  
satisfied, One who  
is satisfied has an  
empty head All  
creatures exert  
and come to rest  
All plants grow to  
maturity and come  
to rest That final  
rest is what's  
called being done;  
completion  
Returning to  
nature is what's  
called eternal life  
Living in the  
present is called  
being enlightened  
One who is not

d. Not to know the  
eternal is to act  
blindly and court  
disaster. Whoever  
knows the eternal  
is open to  
everything.  
Whoever is open  
to everything is  
impartial. To be  
impartial is to be  
universal. To be  
universal is to be  
in accord with  
heaven. To be in  
accord with  
heaven is to be in  
accord with the  
Way. To be in  
accord with the  
Way is to be  
eternal and to live  
free from harm  
even though the  
body dies. up

enlightened lives  
in confusion and  
misery One who  
lives according to  
his nature  
understands  
everything and is  
forbearing One  
who is forbearing  
is righteous One  
who is righteous is  
royal One who is  
royal is divine One  
who is divine  
knows oneself  
One who knows  
oneself has eternal  
life One who has  
eternal life is not  
afraid to die up



## Chapter 17

. Leaders The best leaders the people barely know. The next best they love and praise. The next they fear. And the next they hate. Those who lack trust

The most intelligent leaders bring about results without making those controlled realize that they are being influenced. The less intelligent seek to motivate others by appeals to loyalty, honour, self-interest, and flattery. Those still less intelligent employ fear by making their followers think they will not receive their rewards. The worst try to force others to improve by c

Of the wise of old, people only knew that they existed Later on they loved them and admired them Thereafter they got scared of them And finally the wise were seen as despicable One who

will not be trusted. Then they resort to promises. But when they accomplish their task and complete their work, the people say, "We did it ourselves." up

condemning their conduct. But since, if leaders do not trust their followers then their followers will not trust the leaders, The intelligent leader will be careful not to speak as if he doubted or distrusted his follower's ability to do the job suitably. When the work is done, and as he wanted it done, he will be happy if the followers say: "This is just the way we wanted it." up

can't trust oneself, can't trust another How cautious were the first with their words They proceeded so cautiously that when they were done The people thought they did it themselves up

## Chapter 18

. When the Way is Forgotten  
When the great Way is forgotten, the doctrines of humanity and morality arise. When knowledge and cleverness appear, there emerges great hypocrisy.

When people try to improve upon, and thus deviate from, the way Nature itself naturally functions, they develop artificial codes of right and wrong. When knowledge becomes highly abstract, men are deceived by mistaking abstractions for realities. W

When people deviate from their nature  
Friendliness and righteousness became merits to be earned  
Knowledge and cleverness came into being and lying started to r

When family relationships are not in harmony, filial piety and parental love are advocated. When a country falls into chaos and disorder, there is praise of loyal patriots. up

hen instinctive family sympathies are replaced by rules for proper conduct then parents become "responsible" and children become "dutiful". When corruption replaces genuine benevolence in government, then loyalty oaths are demanded of officials. up

ule Relatives came into conflict with each other and loving each other became a duty Cause when mankind and families get confused Allegiance becomes an order up

## Chapter 19

. What People  
Need Abandon  
religion and  
discard  
cleverness, and  
people will  
benefit a  
hundredfold.  
Abandon  
humanity and  
discard morality,  
and people will  
rediscover love  
and duty.  
Abandon skill  
and discard  
profit, a

Therefore - If we  
ignore intricate  
learning and  
knowledge of petty  
distinctions, we  
shall be many  
times better off. If  
we neglect to insist  
upon the formal  
proprieties of  
etiquette, our  
intuitive  
sympathies will  
return. If we  
abolish  
opportunities for  
profite

Dispose yourself  
of worldly  
knowledge and  
cleverness And it  
will only be good  
for mankind Stop  
pretending to be  
nice and fair, but  
be it Then people  
will love each  
other  
unconditionally  
Dispose yourself  
of the work of  
your hands an

nd there will be  
no thieves or  
robbers. These  
three things  
relate to  
externals and are  
inadequate.  
People need  
what they can  
depend on:  
reveal simplicity;  
embrace the  
natural; control  
selfishness;  
reduce desires.  
up

ering "within the  
law," incentive for  
political corruption  
will disappear. If  
the foregoing three  
principles are  
unclear, then at  
least the following  
are  
understandable:  
Simply be yourself.  
Act naturally.  
Refrain from  
self-assertiveness.  
Avoid  
covetousness. up

d stop serving  
your self-interest  
And there will be  
no thieves or  
robbers anymore  
But these three  
things won't be  
enough What it's  
really about is  
turning back to  
simplicity Giving  
up your  
selfishness and  
not wishing for  
anything up



## Chapter 21

. Within the Elusive Way All-embracing power proceeds only through the Way. What is called the Way is elusive and intangible. Intangible and elusive, yet within it are thought-images. Elusive and intangible, yet within it are objects. Deep and obscure, yet within it is th

Intelligence consists in acting according to Nature. Nature is something which can neither be seen nor touched. Yet all of the forms which can possibly be seen or touched are latent within it. And all of the things that will actually be seen or touched are embedded as potentialities within it. Deep in its depths are activating forces. No m

A righteous and blissful life is approachable only when you follow your conscience The conscience is invisible and impalpable. How can you follow it? It speaks through images, like shadows in the dark But how faintly and obscurely The conscience is hidden but it carries the essentials of everything ins

e life-force. The life-force is very real, and within it is certainty. From the ancient times till now its manifestations have never ceased, by which we may see the beginning of all things. How do I know that the beginnings of all things are so? Through this certainty. up

atter how unplumbable the depths, these forces unfailingly sustain the world as it appears to us. From the beginning until now, they have never ceased to express themselves in appearances. How do I know all this to be so? It is intuitively self-evident, for every existing thing testifies to it, including what appears right here and now. up

ide The true life-force shelters itself inside conscience Everything people know deeply inside is stowed within the conscience It has always been there since the beginning, with many different names The conscience separates truth from lie How do I know all this? My conscience has told me that it's so up

## Chapter 22

. Yielding for Unity  
To yield is to  
preserve unity. To  
bend is to become  
straight. To empty  
oneself is to  
become full. To  
wear oneself out is  
to be renewed. To  
have little is to be  
content. To have  
abundance is to be  
troubled.  
Therefore the wise  
embrace the One  
and become  
examples for the  
world. They do not  
display themselves  
and are therefore i

Dissension  
becomes unity The  
impure becomes  
pure The voids  
shall be filled The  
old becomes new  
One who has  
nothing, receives  
everything One  
who has a lot,  
receives nothing  
One who is wise  
cherishes  
simplicity and in  
this way he is an  
example to the  
world He is  
modest and

llumined. They do  
not justify  
themselves and  
are distinguished.  
They do not make  
claims and are  
therefore given  
credit. They do not  
seek glory and  
therefore are  
leaders. Because  
they do not  
compete, the world  
cannot compete  
with them. Is not  
the ancient saying  
true, "To yield is to  
preserve unity?"  
for true wholeness  
comes from  
turning within. up

therefore he  
excels He doesn't  
have to prove  
himself and that's  
why people trust  
his words He has  
nothing to defend  
and therefore he is  
invulnerable So  
the aphorism of  
the wise of old  
"The imperfect  
becomes perfect"  
is true The perfect  
considers the  
world as his home  
up

## Chapter 23

. Nature Nature says few words. A whirlwind does not last all morning, nor does a rainstorm last a whole day. What causes them? Nature. If even Nature's utterances do not last long, how much less should human beings'? Those who follow the Way are one with the Way. Those wh

Things which act naturally do not need to be told how to act. The wind and rain begin without being ordered, and quit without being commanded. This is the way with all natural beginnings and endings. If Nature does not have to instruct the wind and the rain, how much less should man try to direct them? Whoever acts naturally is Na

One who knows oneself doesn't need a lot of words. A whirlwind doesn't last all morning. A shower doesn't last a whole day. Where do wind and rain come from? They sprout from nature. If nature doesn't endure its rains and storms, then why should a human being have to talk so much? So the One wh

o follow power are one with power. Those who abandon it are one with abandonment. Those one with the Way are welcomed by the Way. Those one with power are welcomed by power. Those one with abandonment are welcomed by abandonment. Those who lack trust will not be trusted. up

ture itself acting. And whoever acts unintelligently is unintelligence in action. By acting naturally, one reaps Nature's rewards. So by acting intelligently, one achieves intelligent goals. Whereas by acting unintelligently, one comes to an unintelligent end. Those who do not trust Nature as a model cannot be trusted as guides. up

o follows his conscience, coincides with his conscience. One who lives an exemplary life, will be an example. One who loses oneself, doesn't know who he is anymore. One who finds oneself, finds bliss. One who loses oneself, loses true life. One who does not trust oneself, will not be trusted. up

## Chapter 24

. Avoid Excess  
Those who stand on tiptoe are not steady. Those who strain their strides cannot long keep up the pace. Those who display themselves do not illuminate. Those who justify themselves are not distinguishable

One who tries to stand on tiptoe cannot stand still. One who stretches his legs too far cannot walk. One who advertises himself too much is ignored. One who is too insistent on his own views finds few to agree with him. One who claims too much credit does

One who stands on tiptoe, doesn't stand firmly One who walks in a forced way, doesn't come far One who is vain, doesn't shine One who justifies oneself, isn't credible One who brags, will

d. Those who make claims are not given credit. Those who seek glory are not leaders. According to the Way these are like extra food and waste, which all creatures detest. Therefore followers of the Way avoid them. up

es not get even what he deserves. One who is too proud is soon humiliated. These, when judged by the standards of Nature, are condemned as "Extremes of greediness and self-destructive activity." Therefore, one who acts naturally avoids such extremes. up

ill be unmasked One who works one's way up, humiliates oneself To a wise man these are nothing but follies One who lives righteously and honestly, refrains oneself from these things up



## Chapter 25

. The Supreme  
There is  
something  
mysterious and  
whole which  
existed before  
heaven and earth,  
silent, formless,  
complete, and  
never changing.  
Living eternally  
everywhere in  
perfection, it is the  
mother of all  
things. I do not  
know its name; I  
call it the Way. If  
forced to define it,  
I shall call it  
supreme.  
Supreme means  
absolute. Absolute  
means ext

Before Creation  
revealed itself  
There was already  
something, perfect  
but formless Quiet  
and unchanging  
Ubiquitous and  
inexhaustible  
People might  
consider it as the  
creating force of  
everything that is I  
cannot describe it,  
but I just call it Tao  
If I have to  
interpret it , I would  
name it "The  
Universe" With  
that Universe I  
mean that which  
extends itself  
everywhere The  
infinite

ending  
everywhere.  
Extending  
everywhere means  
returning to itself.  
Thus the Way is  
supreme. Heaven  
is supreme. Earth  
is supreme. And  
the person is  
supreme. There  
are four supremes  
in the universe,  
and the person is  
one of them. The  
person reflects the  
earth. The earth  
reflects heaven.  
Heaven reflects  
the Way. And the  
Way reflects its  
own nature. up

y extending and  
returning  
Therefore the  
creative is great  
and the creation  
great and so is a  
wise man So there  
is a trinity of  
greatnesses and  
one of them is the  
true human being  
A true human  
being follows his  
nature, nature and  
all its eternally  
unchanging laws  
The laws of nature  
are the eternal  
order of the  
Universe The  
order of the  
Universe is  
well-founded by  
the Unnameable  
up

## Chapter 26

. Self-mastery  
Gravity is the  
foundation of  
levity. Serenity  
masters  
hastiness.  
Therefore the  
wise travel all  
day without  
leaving their  
baggage. In the  
midst of honor  
and glory they

Saneness or  
sobriety is more  
basic than  
frivolity.  
Calmness or  
self-sufficiency is  
superior to being  
agitated.  
Therefore the  
intelligent man,  
though he goes  
on a long  
journey, will  
never depart far  
from his means  
of conveyance.  
No matte

Heavy is the  
source of that  
which is light The  
unmoved mover  
is the origin of all  
movement  
Therefore a true  
human being can  
be in motion all  
day Not because  
it is him moving  
himself But  
because he just  
floats on life Like  
a spectator he e

remain leisurely  
and calm, How  
can a leader of a  
great country  
behave  
lightheartedly  
and frivolously?  
In frivolity, the  
foundation is  
lost. In hasty  
action,  
self-mastery is  
lost. up

r how exciting  
the distractions,  
he never submits  
to their lures.  
What would  
happen if Nature  
were to act  
frivolously? If it  
became  
frivolous, it would  
be deprived of its  
sanity. If it  
became agitated,  
it would lose  
control of itself.  
up

njoys the  
wonderful and  
sparkling  
creation Why  
should he, as the  
centre of the  
world, Consider  
himself minor to  
that world? One  
who knows his  
grandeur, comes  
loose of the  
world One who  
wanders  
restlessly in that  
world, has lost  
oneself up

## Chapter 27

. Using the Light A  
good traveler  
leaves no trace. A  
good speaker  
makes no slips. A  
good accountant  
uses no devices. A  
good door needs  
no bolts to remain  
shut. A good  
fastener needs no  
rope to hold its  
bond. Therefore  
the wise are good  
at helping people,  
and consequently  
no one is rejected.  
They are go

od at saving  
things, and  
consequently  
nothing is wasted.  
This is called using  
the Light.  
Therefore the  
good teach the  
bad, and the bad  
are lessons for the  
good. Those who  
neither value the  
teacher nor care  
for the lesson are  
greatly deluded,  
though they may  
be learned. Such  
is the essential  
mystery. up

llow men  
unconditionally  
Therefore he is  
shepherd of the  
whole creation  
And respects  
every thing that  
lives and grows  
People call this:  
“The light that has  
become human”  
Therefore a true  
human being is a  
mirror for the  
untrue And it's his  
task to point out  
their imperfections  
One who is scared  
to take a look at  
oneself and does  
not love oneself  
Might know a lot of  
things, but he is  
blind It seems odd,  
but it's true up

## Chapter 28

. The Valley of the World Know the male and keep to the female. Become the valley of the world. Being the valley of the world is eternal power and returning to the innocence of a baby. Know the bright and keep to the obscure. Become an example for the world. Being an example for the world is eterna

One who knows his strength and yet stays mild, is the least  
Whoever is the least, is balanced like the open-minded child he once was One who has fathomed the lie is an example for the world One who became human again is an examp

I power and returning to the infinite. Know glory and keep to humility. Become the valley of the world. Being the valley of the world is eternal power and returning to the natural. Breaking up the natural makes instruments. The wise use them and become leaders. Therefore a leader does not break. up

le for the world One knowing oneself, is a knowing among the ignorant One who has returned to his original purity, realizes his grandeur One who has abandoned his origin, becomes civilized To the wise man they are like actors up

## Chapter 29

. Do Not Tamper  
with the World  
Those who take  
over the world  
and act upon it, I  
notice, do not  
succeed. The  
world is a sacred  
vessel, not to be  
tampered with.  
Those who  
tamper with it,  
spoil it. Those  
who se

Whenever  
someone sets out  
to remold the  
world, experience  
teaches that he is  
bound to fail. For  
Nature is already  
as good as it can  
be. It cannot be  
improved upon. He  
who tries to  
redesign it, spoils  
it. He who tries to  
redirect it,  
misleads it.  
Consider how  
Nature operates:  
Some thing

One who thinks  
he is capable of  
improving  
Creation, will not  
succeed  
Creation is  
perfect and  
cannot be  
corrected One  
who intervenes  
in nature, will  
only destroy  
nature One who  
tries to control  
nature, will lose  
to nature  
Because  
everything i

ize it, lose it.  
Some lead, and  
some follow.  
Some blow hot,  
and some blow  
cold. Some are  
strong, and some  
are weak. Some  
are up, and  
some are down.  
Therefore the  
wise avoid  
excess,  
extravagance,  
and pride. up

s precede while  
others follow.  
Some things blow  
one way while  
some blow  
another. Some  
things are strong  
while others are  
weak. Some things  
are going up while  
others are going  
down. Therefore  
the intelligent man  
avoids both  
extremes,  
shunning excess  
in one way as well  
as in the other. up

s what it is and  
everything  
happens as it  
happens At times  
it is warm and  
then it is cold At  
times there are  
storms and then  
it's calm There is  
growth and then  
there is lying  
down A wise  
man lets himself  
flow along with  
the streams of  
life up

## Chapter 30

Force of Arms  
Whoever advises  
a leader according  
to the Way  
opposes conquest  
by force of arms.  
The use of force  
tends to rebound.  
Where armies  
march, thorns and  
brambles grow.  
Whenever a great  
army is formed,  
scarcity and  
famine follow. The  
skillful achieve  
their purposes and  
stop. They dare  
not rely on force.  
They achieve their

Whoever tries to  
help Nature run  
itself does not  
need to use force.  
For force will be  
met with force, and  
wherever force is  
used fighting and  
devastation  
follows. After the  
battle come years  
of destitution. He  
who is wise lets  
well enough alone.  
He does not press  
a victory by further  
conquest. When  
peace has been  
restored, he does  
not behave like an  
arrogant vict

One who  
advocates a  
righteous world,  
uses no violence  
Because One who  
uses violence,  
provokes violence  
And where discord  
rules there is  
chaos And after  
times of conflict  
lean years will  
follow The  
righteous one  
does what he can  
and forces nothing  
Is not proud about  
what he achieves  
Does n

purposes, but do  
not glory in them.  
They achieve their  
purposes, but do  
not celebrate  
them. They  
achieve their  
purposes, but do  
not take pride in  
them. They  
achieve their  
purposes, but  
without violence.  
Things reach their  
prime and then  
decline. Violence  
is contrary to the  
Way. Whatever is  
contrary to the  
Way will soon  
perish. up

or. When security  
has been  
regained, he does  
not gloat like a  
conqueror. When  
he gets what he  
needs, he does  
not destroy those  
who have been  
defeated.  
Whenever he does  
something which  
he has to do, he  
does it without  
cruelty. When  
things reach  
maturity, they  
decay of  
themselves. So  
cruelty is  
unnatural.  
Whoever acts  
unnaturally will  
come to an  
unnatural finish. up

ot brag about what  
he achieves Does  
not boast about  
what he achieves  
He only does what  
he does because  
that's all he can do  
And he never uses  
power or violence  
Civilizations which  
have reached their  
peaks Usher in  
their decay  
Civilizations are  
unnatural And  
what's unnatural,  
will perish up

## Chapter 31

. War and Peace  
Weapons are tools  
of destruction  
hated by people.  
Therefore  
followers of the  
Way never use  
them. In peace  
leaders favor the  
creative left. In war  
they favor the  
destructive right.  
Weapons are tools  
of destruction, not  
used by good  
leaders. When  
their use cannot  
be avoided, t

How ingenious  
weaponry may  
seem to be,  
though it will  
always be  
disastrous rubbish  
Everybody hates it  
A righteous man  
saves himself from  
it While a true man  
will not soil his  
hands with it A  
fighter grabs for it  
Weapons are not  
good for meek  
people They bring  
nothing but trouble  
One who is wise  
will never ever use  
a weapon  
Because peace  
and quietness are  
more precious to  
him He doesn

he best policy is  
calm restraint.  
Even in victory  
there is no glory.  
Those who  
celebrate victory  
delight in  
slaughter. Those  
who delight in  
slaughter will not  
be successful  
leaders. The killing  
of many should be  
mourned with  
sorrow. A victory  
should be  
celebrated with  
funeral  
ceremonies. up

't enjoy victory  
Because one who  
enjoys victory  
Enjoys his fellow  
men getting killed  
And one who  
enjoys their fellow  
men getting killed  
Will never find  
peace in oneself  
Prosperity is  
considered as a  
personal merit  
Misfortune on the  
other hand is  
considered as an  
ironic freak Victory  
is the merit of men  
And defeat the  
blame of the  
commander But  
victory and defeat  
only brings losers  
up

## Chapter 32

The Natural Way  
The Way is  
absolute and  
undefined. Like  
natural uncarved  
wood in  
simplicity, yet  
none in the world  
can overcome it.  
If leaders would  
hold to it, the  
whole world  
would serve  
them  
spontaneously.  
Heaven and  
earth join, and  
gentle rain f

Nature is always  
indeterminable.  
Although, in its  
original simplicity,  
it may appear to  
be helpless, no  
one else can tell it  
what to do. If  
legislators and  
administrators  
could keep this in  
mind, everybody  
would obey their  
laws without  
enforcement.  
When opposites  
supplement each  
other, everything is  
harmonious.  
Without  
compulsion, each  
supports the other.  
But when boundar

The Unspeakable  
is eternal and is  
not to be spoken  
of in words Just  
like a rough piece  
of wood, it's not  
useful to anyone If  
leaders were an  
example of true  
living Everyone  
would join his true  
nature at the same  
time The heavens  
would dew and the  
clouds rain justice  
And without  
human intervening  
That altogether  
would benefit e

alls, beyond the  
command of  
anyone, evenly  
upon all. When  
civilization arose,  
names began.  
With names, one  
should know  
when to stop.  
Knowing when to  
stop, frees one  
from danger. The  
Way in the world  
is like rivers and  
streams flowing  
into the sea. up

ies between  
opposites appear,  
then the boundary  
lines are marked  
out. Once one  
begins to  
differentiate  
between one thing  
and another, how  
will we know  
where to stop? To  
know when to stop  
making distinctions  
is to be free from  
error. The true  
relationship of  
every determinate  
thing to Nature is  
reintegrative, like  
all the rivers and  
rivulets ever  
running to their  
ocean. up

very single thing  
that lives beneath  
the firmament But  
when discord is  
born Everything  
must have a name  
Keep in mind that  
when everything  
has a name, You'll  
have to stop all  
that Because one  
who stops will  
bounce off danger  
Compared to the  
twisted tributaries  
of mistake The  
straight and simple  
road is like a  
powerful stream  
up



## Chapter 33

. Inner Power

Those who know others are wise.

Those who know themselves are enlightened.

Those who overcome others require force.

Those who overcome themselves need strength

He who knows much about others may be learned, but he who understands himself is more intelligent. He who controls others may be powerful, but he who has mastered himself is mightier still. He who receives his happiness from others may be

One who sees through the other is clever One knowing oneself is wise One who conquers the other is powerful One conquering oneself is inviolable One who is satis

. Those who are content are wealthy. Those who persevere have will power. Those who do not lose their center endure. Those who die but maintain their power live eternally. up

rich, but he who whose contentment is self-willed has inexhaustible wealth. He who occupies a place provided for him by others may live a long life, but he who dwells in his own self-contained place, even though he decays, is eternal. up

fied is rich One that wants a lot is busy all the time One who stays oneself, is a four-square fellow One who dies before dying, lives in the present forever up

## Chapter 34

. The Great Way  
The great Way  
flows  
everywhere, both  
left and right. All  
things derive  
their life from it,  
and it does not  
turn away from  
them. It  
accomplishes its  
work, but does  
not take  
possession. It  
provides for and  
nourishes eve

Ultimate reality is  
all-pervasive; it is  
immanent  
everywhere. All  
other things owe  
their existence to it  
and draw their  
sustenance from it,  
without anyone  
being refused.  
Having created  
and and nurtured  
them, it does not  
demand title to  
them. Even though  
it has provided for  
all, it refuses to  
dominate over a  
single one

That which makes  
everything exist, is  
present  
everywhere It  
spreads itself  
throughout the  
entire Creation  
Everything owes  
its existence to It,  
everything to its  
own nature It gives  
everything for  
nothing It  
cherishes and  
guards everything  
and everyone,

rything, but does  
not control them.  
Always without  
desires, it may  
be considered  
small. The  
destination of all  
things, yet  
claiming nothing,  
it may be  
considered great.  
Because it never  
claims  
greatness, its  
greatness is  
achieved. up

. Since it asks  
nothing in return  
for its services, it  
may appear as of  
little worth. But all  
things return home  
to it again, even  
though they do not  
know that they are  
being called home.  
Therefore it may  
be thought of as  
ultimate. Since it  
never claims  
ultimacy for itself,  
it is, by that very  
fact, ultimate  
indeed. up

but expects  
nothing in return  
Because It does  
not wish for  
anything, It seems  
to be important It  
makes everything  
appear and  
disappear again  
But Itself is eternal  
Therefore the one  
who is wise is  
modest And  
because he is  
modest, His  
actions are grand  
up

## Chapter 35

. The  
Inexhaustible  
Way Hold to the  
great form, and  
all the world  
follows, following  
without meeting  
harm, in health,  
peace, and  
happiness. Music  
and delicacie

He who grasps the  
ultimate structure  
of reality draws  
everyone to him.  
They approach  
him without being  
harmed, but find  
security,  
satisfaction, and  
contentment.  
Particular goods of  
various kinds  
attract the  
interests of men as  
they travel through  
life. But the  
all-pervasive way  
of Nature attracts  
no attenti

For one who  
beholds the  
perfect  
arrangement of  
things Everything  
falls in its rightful  
place Nothing  
can harm him,  
and rest and  
peace will fall to  
him Along the  
way there are

s to eat induce  
travelers to stay.  
But the Way is  
mild to the taste.  
Looked at, it is  
invisible.  
Listened to, it is  
inaudible.  
Applied, it is  
inexhaustible. up

on to itself (for its  
true nature is not  
found to be in  
particulars). Even  
though it is present  
in the mouth, it  
remains untasted.  
Even though it is  
embedded in all  
objects, it remains  
unseen. Even  
though it  
permeates sound,  
it remains  
unheard. Yet, no  
matter how much  
we use it, it can  
never be  
exhausted. up

travellers who  
yield music and  
feasts Because  
the road to  
self-knowledge is  
acrid and  
unpleasant Not  
pleasant to face  
Painful to hear  
But giving an  
inexhaustible  
strength up

## Chapter 36

. The Mystic Light In order to contract, it is necessary first to expand. In order to weaken, it is necessary first to strengthen. In order to reduce, it is necessary first to build up. In order to receive

The purpose of contracting (returning to Nature) is served by expanding (emerging out of Nature in the first place). The purpose of weakening (subsiding or satisfying of desire) is served by strengthening (arousing the will to live). The purpose of decline (of individual self-assertion) is served by arising (of individuality). The purpose of takin

Only what's stretched out can be pulled together Only what's fortified can be weakened Only what's increased can be decreased Only one

, it is necessary first to give. This is called the mystic Light. The soft and gentle overcome the hard and strong. As fish stay in the deep water, so sharp weapons of the state should not be displayed. up

g away (culminating or perfecting life) is served by being given (ie., "the last of life for which the first was made"). This is the most penetrating insight into the way of life. The giving in or finishing always triumphs over the starting out. Just as a fish should not be taken out of water, So a sword should never be taken from its scabbard. up

who has, can lose That must be clear Soft overcomes hard Weak overcomes strong Fishes belong in water Weapons have to be destroyed up

## Chapter 37

. The Way Never  
Interferes The  
Way never  
interferes, yet  
through it  
everything is  
done. If leaders  
would follow the  
Way, the world  
would be  
reformed of its  
own accord.  
When reformed  
and des

Nature never  
acts, yet it  
activates  
everything. If  
legislators and  
administrators  
would behave  
likewise, each  
thing would  
develop in  
accordance with  
its own nature.  
Just as, when  
things develop, t

The Eternal  
Creating does  
nothing And yet it  
does everything  
If leaders would  
give in to it The  
aspect of the  
world would  
change of itself  
But since people

iring to act, let  
them be  
restrained by  
what is simply  
natural.  
Undefined  
simplicity is free  
of desires. Being  
free of desires, it  
is serene; and  
the world finds  
peace of its own  
accord. up

hose which  
become  
passionate are  
restrained by that  
passionless one  
which activates  
them, So the way  
to restrain men's  
passions is by  
dispassionate  
restraint. And  
thus all passions  
will subside. up

have so much to  
wish for Only I  
can be an  
example The  
example of true  
simplicity And  
when the people  
decide to follow  
me The whole  
world will be in  
peace up

## Chapter 38



## Chapter 40

. Movement of  
the Way  
Returning is the  
movement of the  
Way. Gentleness  
is the method o

Nature alternates  
dynamically.  
When it  
completes what it  
is doing, then

One who  
deviates from the  
right and simple  
road Will be  
pulled towards it  
again This  
occurs with a

f the Way. All  
things in the  
world come from  
being, and being  
comes from  
non-being. up

it starts all over  
again. All that is  
springs from  
such alternation.  
up

mild touch The  
whole creation  
comes into  
existence The  
existing out of  
the unnameable  
unexisting up



## Chapter 41

. What the Way is  
Like When the  
wise hear the  
Way, they practice  
it diligently. When  
the mediocre hear  
of the Way, they  
doubt it. When the  
foolish hear of the  
Way, they laugh  
out loud. If it were  
not laughed at, it  
would not be the  
Way. Therefore it  
is said, "The  
enlightenment of  
the Way seems  
like dullness;  
progression in the  
Way seem like  
regression; the  
even path of the  
Way seems to go  
up and down." G

reat power  
appears like a  
valley. Great purity  
appears tarnished.  
Great character  
appears  
insufficient. Solid  
character appears  
weak. True  
integrity appears  
changeable. Great  
space has no  
corners. Great  
ability takes time  
to mature. Great  
music has the  
subtlest sound.  
Great form has no  
shape. The Way is  
hidden and  
indescribable. Yet  
the Way alone is  
adept at providing  
for all and bringing  
fulfillment. up

## Chapter 42

. All Things The Way produced the One; the One produced two; two produced three; and three produced all things. All things have the receptivity of the female and the activity of the male. Through union with the life force they blend in harmony. People

Nature first begets one thing. The one thing begets another. The two produce a third. In this way, all things are begotten. Why? Because all things are impregnated by two alternating tendencies, the tendency towards completion and the tendency towards initiation, which acting together, complement each other. Most men

The unspeakable gives birth to one One to a second And out of the second arises the third The third brings the whole creation to life Everything is carried by the dark and comes to light The breath of Emptiness creates order People hate to be alone, unimportant and use

People hate being orphaned, lonely, and unworthy. Yet kings and nobles call themselves such. Often gain can be a loss, and loss can be a gain. What others teach, I teach also: "The violent die a violent death." I shall make this primary in my teaching. up

People dislike to be considered of no account, lowly, unworthy. Yet intelligent leaders call themselves thus. For people are admired for their humility and despised for their pride. There are many other ways of illustrating what I am teaching: "Extremists reach untimely ends." This saying may be taken as a good example. up

less And yet that is what a true man takes pleasure in One who becomes smaller, becomes bigger One who becomes bigger, becomes smaller I only tell what everybody already knows: One who lives in a complicated way, dies in a complicated way That is what it's all about up

## Chapter 43

. The Value of  
Non-action The  
softest things in  
the world  
overcome the  
hardest.  
Non-being  
penetrates even  
where there is no  
space. T

That which is  
most yielding  
eventually  
overcomes what  
is most resistant.  
That which is not  
becomes that  
which is. Acting  
without coercin

The softest is  
stronger than the  
very hardest  
That which  
makes  
everything be  
what it is,  
penetrates  
everything  
Therefore I know  
that it's wise to  
leave an

hrough this I  
know the value  
of non-action.  
Teaching without  
words and the  
value of  
non-action are  
understood by  
few in the world.  
up

g or being  
coerced is best.  
Guiding by  
example rather  
than by words is  
most successful.  
Such simple  
truths are so  
hard to  
understand. up

d not do anything  
That one doesn't  
need lessons for  
it That of all  
doings, leaving is  
where true  
happiness lies In  
this world only a  
few understand  
this up

## Chapter 44

. How to Endure  
Fame or your  
life, which do you  
love more? Life  
or material  
wealth, which is  
more valuable?  
Loss or gain,  
which is worse?  
Therefore those  
who desire m

Esteem by  
others or  
self-esteem,  
which is better?  
To value things  
or to value  
yourself, which is  
better? To have  
more or to have  
less, which is  
worse? The  
more you have,  
the more you  
have to lose. The  
more you

What comes first,  
life or status?  
What's more  
important to you,  
yourself or your  
possessions?  
What's worse,  
having or losing?  
One who wants a  
lot pays a high  
price One who  
has a lot, ha

ost spend most.  
Those who hoard  
most lose most.  
Those who are  
contented are  
not disappointed.  
Those who know  
when to stop  
prevent danger.  
Thus they can  
long endure. up

value things, the  
less you value  
your self. The  
more you  
depend on  
others for  
esteem, the less  
you are  
self-sufficient. He  
who knows how  
to discriminate  
wisely avoids  
danger, And  
continues safely  
on his way. up

s a lot to lose But  
one who is  
satisfied knows  
neither fear nor  
disgrace And  
one who has  
stopped playing  
a part in the  
game will never  
be afraid again  
and will live  
happily ever after  
up

## Chapter 45

Skill Seems  
Awkward The  
greatest  
perfection seems  
incomplete, but  
its utility is never  
impaired. The  
greatest fullness  
seems empty,  
but its use  
cannot be  
exhausted. What  
is most direct s

What is most  
complete is still  
incomplete: Yet it  
is as complete as  
it can be. That  
which has  
achieved the most,  
still has the whole  
of its future yet to  
be achieved:  
Hence it will not  
stop achieving.  
Make a thing as  
straight as  
possible; Yet it is  
still crooked or will  
become crooked.  
Acquire the  
greatest skill

Perfection seems  
unfinished to this  
world But it never  
perishes  
Fullness is empty  
to the world But  
it's inexhaustible  
That which is  
correct, is  
incorrect to the  
world W

eems devious.  
The greatest skill  
seems awkward.  
The greatest  
eloquence  
seems like  
stuttering.  
Movement  
overcomes cold.  
Stillness  
overcomes heat.  
The serene and  
calm are guides  
for all. up

; And there will still  
be endless skill to  
be acquired.  
Develop the  
greatest power of  
expression; And  
there will be much  
that is  
unexpressed and  
inexpressible. The  
same may be said  
about activity and  
passivity and cold  
and heat. Only he  
who fully accepts  
these alternations  
is the best guide  
for all to follow. up

isdom seems  
foolish to the  
world Telling the  
truth a disgrace  
Like movement  
chases away  
coldness And  
rest cools down  
Purity and  
calmness show  
one the right  
direction up

## Chapter 46

. Contentment  
When the world  
lives in accord  
with the Way,  
horses work on  
farms. When the  
world does not  
live in accord  
with the Way, the  
cavalry practices  
in the parks

When what is  
natural prevails in  
human affairs,  
horses forced to  
train for racing are  
returned to the  
fertile pastures.  
When artificiality  
prevails in human  
affairs, horses are  
trained for war and  
are restricted to  
walled enclosures.  
There is no greater  
evil than desiring  
to change others -  
(to take from or  
give to others what  
they do not, of  
their o

If men lived by  
their nature  
Horses would  
gallop in the  
open air But  
since men got  
civilized Battle  
horses standing  
at the frontier  
There is no  
bigger curse than  
dissatisfact

. The greatest  
temptation to  
crime is desire.  
The greatest  
curse is  
discontent. The  
greatest calamity  
is greed.  
Whoever is  
content with  
contentment is  
always content.  
up

wn accord, want to  
give or take).  
There is no greater  
misfortune than  
desiring to change  
oneself - being  
discontented with  
one's lot. There is  
no greater vice  
than desiring to  
change things - (to  
possess, control,  
or reconstruct their  
natures). Only he  
who is satisfied  
with whatever  
satisfactions his  
own nature  
provides for him is  
truly satisfied. up

ion Nothing more  
disastrous than  
being discontent  
with life Nothing  
more fatal than  
being eager for  
possessions One  
who knows the  
peace of  
satisfaction, is  
always satisfied  
up

## Chapter 47

. Understanding  
One can know  
the world without  
going outside.  
One can see the  
Way of heaven  
without looking  
out the window.  
The further

Without going  
out-of-doors, one  
can know all he  
needs to know.  
Without even  
looking out of his  
window, one can  
grasp the nature  
of everything.  
Without going  
beyond his own  
nature, one can  
achieve ultim

Without leaving  
my house, I  
understand the  
whole world  
Without looking  
outside, I see the  
perfect order The  
more you know,  
the le

one goes the  
less one knows.  
Therefore the  
wise know  
without going  
about,  
understand  
without seeing,  
and accomplish  
without acting.  
up

ate wisdom.  
Therefore the  
intelligent man  
knows all he  
needs to know  
without going  
away, And he  
sees all he  
needs to see  
without looking  
elsewhere, And  
does all he  
needs to do  
without undue  
exertion. up

ss you'll  
understand One  
who is wise  
doesn't need to  
travel He  
understands  
without looking  
Does nothing but  
achieves  
everything up

## Chapter 48

. Doing Less The pursuit of learning is to increase day by day. The practice of the Way is to decrease day by day. Less and less is done until one

While day by day the overzealous student stores up facts for future use, He who has learned to trust nature finds need for ever fewer external directions. He will discard formula after formula, until he reaches the conclusion: Let Nature take its course

Gathering knowledge makes life more complicated each time one gathers  
Gathering wisdom makes life easier each time one gathers  
Each time, more and more simple until simplicity is reached Just by I

reaches non-action. When nothing is done, nothing is left undone. The world is led by not interfering. Those who interfere cannot lead the world.  
up

. By letting each thing act in accordance with its own nature, everything that needs to be done gets done. The best way to manage anything is by making use of its own nature; For a thing cannot function properly when its own nature has been disrupted. up

eaving, one man can achieve everything One who wants nothing anymore, doesn't feel the need to do a thing, has conquered oneself One who wants a lot has to do a lot and is as a slave to oneself up



## Chapter 49

The Power of Goodness The wise have no mind-set. They regard the people's minds as their own. They are good to people who are good. They are also good to people who are not good. This is the power of goodness. They are honest to those

The intelligent man is not willful. He accepts what others will for themselves as his will for them. Those who appear as good, he accepts, And those who appear as bad, he accepts; For Nature accepts both. Those who appear faithful, he accepts, And those who app

A wise man has no opinion at all. Therefore he can easily put himself in someone else's position. He accepts everybody and everything for what it is. In spite of any behaviour, He trusts the honest and the unfair. And naturally they bec

who are honest. They are also honest to those who are dishonest. This is the power of honesty. The wise live in the world peacefully and harmoniously. The people share a common heart, and the wise treat them as their own children. up

ear unfaithful, he accepts; For Nature accepts both. The intelligent man treats every kind of nature impartially, And will good to one as much as the another. All people admire the intelligent man, Because he regards them all as a mother regards her children. up

ome fair-minded. He trusts the reliable and the unreliable. And naturally all will become reliable. A wise man feels one with all people. They are all just as precious to him. They look and listen to him. And all are as children to him. up

## Chapter 50

Those Who  
Preserve Life  
Coming into life  
and going out at  
death, the organs  
of life are thirteen;  
the organs of  
death are thirteen;  
and these thirteen  
make life  
vulnerable to  
death. Why is this  
so? Because they  
feed life too  
grossly. It is said  
that those who  
preserve life walk  
the earth without  
fearing tigers and  
wild buffalo, and in  
ba

It is natural for  
man to be born  
and to die. And it is  
natural for each of  
his parts to be  
born and to die  
and to evolve  
through its life  
cycle. Why do men  
become so  
perturbed and  
anxious to prolong  
the life of each  
part when  
endangered? The  
truth is that  
whatever is natural  
is good. Since it is  
natural for

Humans come and  
go Their bodies as  
the seat of life  
Their bodies as  
the seat of death  
Humans get old  
and decay Why is  
that? It's because  
they are already  
dead, but think  
that they're living  
There have been  
stories told and  
written about  
people who had  
found true life And  
wandered aroun

ttle they are not  
touched by  
weapons of war.  
The wild buffalo's  
horns find nothing  
to gore; the tiger's  
claws find nothing  
to tear; and  
weapons' points  
find nothing to  
pierce. Why is this  
so? Because they  
have nothing for  
death to enter.  
(Note: The thirteen  
organs of life may  
refer to the nine  
openings in the  
body and the four  
limbs.) up

man to dies  
anyway, being  
assisted by horn or  
claw or spear in  
bringing about his  
death in no way  
endangers his  
nature. No wild  
buffalo horn can  
change the course  
of Nature. No  
tiger's claw can act  
unnaturally. No  
soldier's spear can  
go against Nature.  
Why? Because  
death is natural,  
but Nature cannot  
die. up

d the earth Not  
afraid of tigers or  
rhinos Those who  
avoided weapons  
and violence And  
lived in harmony  
with all creatures  
Therefore no  
creature felt  
threatened by  
them And no  
weapon could  
harm them Why is  
that? Because  
they were only  
living And that's  
where there is no  
room for death up

## Chapter 51

. Mystical Power  
The Way produces  
all things. Power  
nourishes them.  
Matter gives them  
physical form.  
Environment  
shapes their  
abilities. Therefore  
all things respect  
the Way and honor  
power. The Way is  
respected, and  
power is honored  
without anyone's  
order and always  
naturally.  
Therefore the Way  
p

Nature produces  
things, and  
intelligence guides  
them. Although  
different in kind,  
each thing has its  
own self-sufficient  
intelligence to  
guide it. Nothing  
can fail to emulate  
Nature and  
intelligence by  
embodying them  
within its own life.  
Such emulation is  
not demanded, but  
occurs of its own  
accord. Nature  
origin

The Unspeakable  
makes all things  
appear The active  
force determines  
their nature Their  
nature determines  
their shape The  
circumstance  
determines their  
final appearance  
Therefore all  
creatures, With the  
exception of erring  
mankind, honour  
the Unspeakable  
And live according  
to their natures  
This is all a natural  
process An

roduces all things,  
and power  
nourishes them,  
caring for them  
and developing  
them, sheltering  
them and  
comforting them,  
nurturing them and  
protecting them,  
producing them  
but not possessing  
them, helping  
them but not  
obligating them,  
guiding them but  
not controlling  
them. This is  
mystical power. up

ates and suckles,  
rears and  
develops, protects  
and provides for,  
and guides and  
perfects all things.  
Whatever is  
produced, Nature  
accepts it for what  
it is. However it  
behaves, Nature  
lets it follow its  
own way.  
Whatever its  
fortune, Nature  
injects no external  
interference. Such  
is Nature's  
marvelous  
sagacity. up

d nobody rewards  
them for it The  
Unspeakable  
makes them live,  
feeds them, makes  
them grow Fulfils  
them, gives them  
peace, supports  
and guards them It  
makes them live,  
but never forces  
them It takes them  
along the stream  
of life, but does not  
possess It makes  
mature, but does  
not control That is  
an unfathomable  
mystery up

## Chapter 52

. Practicing the Eternal The beginning of the universe is the mother of all things. Those who discover the mother understand the children. Understanding the children and returning to the mother, they live always free from harm. Close the mouth, shut the doors, and al

Nature, because it has mothered all, may be regarded as Mother Nature. He who understands Mother Nature, understands her children. But to avoid the children's mistakes, one should follow close to Mother Nature herself, If throughout his life he desires a safe guide. If one remains silent and keeps to himself,

The world sprouts from something People could call it the mother of the world When one knows that mother, one knows her child One who becomes like that child again, will know the mother And for the rest of his life nothing can harm him ever again He won't criticize anyone and lets no one influence him And his life will be without worries But one who co

I of life is without strain. Open the mouth, meddle with affairs, and all of life is beyond help. Seeing the small is insight; to stay with the gentle is strength. Use the Light, return to insight, and thereby be preserved from harm. This is practicing the eternal. up

he will not fail to fulfill his life; But is he gives advice and meddles in others' affairs, he invites trouble. If you see what is small as it sees itself, And accept what is weak for what strength it has, and use what is dim for the light it gives, Then all will go well. This is called acting naturally. up

ndemns others and whose interests concern only himself Will be full of worries the rest of his life One that sees a gleam of light in darkness sees the light at the end of the tunnel Holding on to that gleam of light requires strength One who follows that light, turns back to the original light Then all danger is gone And you'll live the eternal life up

## Chapter 53

. Leaders in Robbery Those with even a scrap of sense walk on the main way and fear only straying from the path. The main way is smooth and easy, but people like to be side-tracked. While the courts are arrayed in splendor, the fields are f

Let us be intelligent and follow Nature itself. Let us not stray. Nature's way is simple and easy, but men prefer the intricate and artificial. When they congregate in artistically engineered cities, and neglect

When I possess True Knowledge I will stroll on the right and simple road I will avoid side paths Because the straight road is easy to walk But most people love the narrow side paths The residences of the rich are neat and clean But the fields of the poor are filled w

ull of weeds, and the granaries are empty. Yet some wear embroidered clothes, carry sharp swords, over-indulge themselves with food and drink, and have more possessions than they can use. They are leaders in robbery. This is not the Way. up

their farms, their food supply is cut off. When they bedeck themselves with ornaments and weapons, and display their fancy foods and rich properties, they thereby invite thievery. This is acting unnaturally. up

ith weeds And their granaries are empty The elite wear generously-decorated and expensive clothes Sharp swords hang on their waists They stuff and they swill They lose themselves in possession and wealth They flaunt their stolen gear Now, isn't that conscienceless? up

## Chapter 54

. Power What is well established cannot be uprooted. What is firmly held cannot slip away. The power of sacrifice continues on from generation to generation. Cultivated in the person, power becomes real. Cultivated in the family, power becomes abundant. Cultivated in the community, power endure

One who is rooted in this unfair world, Won't be easy to unsettle One who holds on to that world, can't let go Therefore their children will suffer until the third and fourth generation But one who follows his conscience Will lead an impeccable life One who takes care that his fellow men follow their conscience, Makes them flourish One who takes care that his neighbours follow their conscience, Makes t

s. Cultivated in the nation, power flourishes. Cultivated in the world, power becomes universal. Therefore see the person as a person, the family as a family, the community as a community, the nation as a nation, and the world as universal. How do I know that the world is like this? By this. up

hem examples for everybody else And when all of mankind follows its conscience, There shall be a paradise on earth Look at yourself if you want to understand yourself Discover the connections and patterns in the way your nearest relations, Cities and the nations, get on with each other Because what's on a small scale, is on a big scale, too How do I know it is that way? Because I've done this myself up

## Chapter 55

. Know Harmony  
Those filled with  
power are like  
new-born children.  
Poisonous insects  
will not sting them;  
ferocious beasts  
will not pounce  
upon them;  
predatory birds will  
not swoop down  
on them. Their  
bones are pliable,  
their muscles  
tender, but their  
grip is firm. They  
have never known  
the union of man  
and woman, but  
the organ is fully  
formed, meaning  
that the vital  
essence is strong.  
Th

He who is  
intelligent is like a  
little child.  
Poisonous insects  
do not sting him.  
Ferocious beasts  
do not attack him.  
Wild birds do not  
claw him. His  
bones are soft, his  
muscles weak, yet  
his grip is strong.  
Because he has  
no urge for sexual  
union, he is fully  
satisfied. His  
vitality is intact. He  
can cry all day  
without getting  
hoarse. His  
existence is

A true human  
being is like a  
new-born baby  
Wasps and  
scorpions won't  
sting it, snakes  
and adders won't  
bite it Raptors and  
wild animals won't  
attack it Its bones  
and muscles are  
soft and flexible,  
yet it has a pretty  
tight grip Sex and  
libido are strange  
to it, but its little  
penis already is  
able to stiffen That  
is because its  
nature is not yet  
disturbed by  
thoughts It can yell  
all d

ey may cry all day  
without getting  
hoarse, meaning  
that the harmony  
is perfect. To know  
harmony is to be in  
accord with the  
eternal. To know  
the eternal is to be  
enlightened. To try  
to force life is  
ominous. To force  
the vital essence  
with the mind is  
violence. The  
prime is past, and  
decay follows,  
meaning that it is  
contrary to the  
Way. Whatever is  
contrary to the  
Way will soon  
perish. up

harmonious. To  
know such  
harmony is to be in  
accord with  
Nature. To be in  
accord with Nature  
is to be achieving  
the goal of life. But  
to seek excitement  
is to invite  
calamity. Those  
too eager for  
activity soon  
become fatigued.  
For when things  
exhaust their  
vigour, they age  
quickly. Such  
impatience is  
against Nature.  
What is against  
Nature dies young.  
up

ay without getting  
a hoarse throat  
Because  
everything is still  
perfectly in  
balance  
Experiencing that  
balance is called  
"living in the  
eternal present"  
Living without past  
or future is called  
"being wise" Every  
attempt to extend  
life is pointless  
One who wants to  
control his life,  
restrains oneself It  
is unnatural that  
things wither That  
which is unnatural  
will come to an  
early end up

## Chapter 56

. Mystical Unity  
Those who know  
do not speak.  
Those who  
speak do not  
know. Close the  
mouth; shut the  
doors. Smooth  
the sharpness;  
untie the tangles.  
Dim the glare;  
calm the turmoil.  
This

He who is wise  
keeps silent. He  
who advises is a  
fool. The wise  
man shuts his  
mouth, Closes  
his doors, Curbs  
his anxieties,  
Withdraws from  
entanglements,  
Remains  
untempted by  
attractions, And  
retains his  
self-sufficiency.  
Nature is  
profoundly

Those who have  
experienced the  
Mystery don't  
speak about it  
Those who do  
speak about it  
have not  
experienced the  
Mystery Don't try  
to speak about the  
Unspeakable That  
which cannot be  
seen, heard, felt or  
tasted The shapes  
fade The edges  
weaken Confusio

is mystical unity.  
Those achieving  
it are detached  
from friends and  
enemies, from  
benefit and  
harm, from honor  
and disgrace.  
Therefore they  
are the most  
valuable people  
in the world. up

impartial. It  
cannot be  
persuaded by  
pampering, Nor  
dissuaded by  
scoffing. It  
cannot be  
tempted by  
bribes, Nor  
influenced by  
injury. It cannot  
be cajoled by  
flattery, Nor  
chagrined by  
slander. Thus it  
is the most  
reliable thing in  
the world. up

n disappears The  
light brightens The  
unrest is  
extinguished  
That's what they  
call a "Mystical  
Experience"  
Neither affection  
nor hate can move  
him Profit nor loss  
will touch him  
Honour nor  
disgrace will harm  
him Therefore he  
is the world's  
noblest man up



## Chapter 57

. Love Peace  
States are  
governed by  
justice. Wars are  
waged by  
violations. The  
world is mastered  
by nonintervention.  
How do I know  
this? By this: The  
more restrictions  
there are, the  
poorer the people.  
The more sharp  
weapons, the  
more trouble in the  
state. The more  
clever cunning, t

With laws men rule  
a state With ruses  
people make war  
Without laws and  
without ruses you'll  
have a peaceful  
mankind How do I  
know this? Well,  
because of the  
following: The  
more orders and  
prescriptions, the  
more defiant the  
people become  
The more arming,  
the bigger the  
chaos The more  
knowledge and  
science, the more  
machines and  
artificialit

he more  
contrivances. The  
more rules and  
regulations, the  
more thieves and  
robbers. Therefore  
the wise say, "Do  
not interfere, and  
people transform  
themselves. Love  
peace, and people  
do what is right.  
Do not intervene,  
and people  
prosper. Have no  
desires, and  
people live  
simply." up

of law-breakers  
and tax-evaders.  
This is why the  
intelligent man  
concludes: When I  
attend to my own  
business, other  
people are able to  
attend to theirs.  
When I exemplify  
self-reliance, other  
people will devote  
themselves to the  
exercise of their  
own intelligence.  
When I make no  
demands upon  
them, other people  
themselves will  
prosper. When I  
express no desire  
to interfere in their  
lives, others will  
become genuinely  
self-sufficient. up

y The more rules  
and decisions, the  
more thieves and  
robbers Therefore  
a wise man says: I  
don't do anything,  
and the people  
change  
spontaneously I  
take rest, and the  
people become  
honest  
spontaneously I  
don't make an  
issue of anything,  
and the people  
find wealth inside  
themselves I don't  
want anything, and  
the people return  
to simplicity up

## Chapter 58

. Results of  
Process When  
the government  
is relaxed,  
people are  
happy. When the  
government is  
strict, people are  
anxious. Good  
fortune leans on  
bad fortune; bad  
fortune hides  
behind good  
fortune. Who  
knows the results  
of process? Is  
the

When government  
governs little,  
people are happy.  
When government  
governs much,  
people are  
miserable. Thus  
happiness  
depends on little,  
And misery  
depends on much.  
What does the  
desire to govern  
come to? To  
restrict interferers  
is itself  
interference. So  
attempts to  
increase  
happiness end  
only in misery.  
Mankind has

The fewer rules  
and laws there  
are, the happier  
mankind will be  
The more rules  
and laws, the  
more there will  
be of  
dissatisfaction  
and conflicts  
Someone's  
wealth comes at  
the expense of  
someone else's  
poverty Mi

re no justice?  
When the just  
become unjust,  
goodness  
becomes evil.  
People have  
been deluded for  
a long time.  
Therefore the  
wise are square  
but not cornered,  
sharp but not  
cutting, straight  
but not strained,  
brilliant but not  
dazzling. up

been foolish for so  
long a time! The  
intelligent man  
knows what is  
best, but does not  
make others  
conform. He  
knows directions,  
but does not  
direct. He pursues  
the straightest way  
to the goal, but  
does not urge  
others to deviate  
from their course.  
He is enlightened,  
but he cares not  
whether others  
see his light. up

sery for one is  
the result of  
someone else's  
wealth When will  
this ever stop?  
One who is wise  
is righteous and  
won't play that  
game He is just  
and fair and will  
never hurt  
anybody He  
shines, but does  
not blind up

## Chapter 59

. Be Frugal In  
leading people  
and serving  
heaven it is best  
to be frugal.  
Being frugal is to  
be prepared from  
the start. Being  
prepared from  
the start is to  
build up power.  
By building up  
power nothing is  
impossible. If  
nothing is i

In managing men  
or anything else,  
the intelligent  
man uses  
self-restraint.  
Only by  
self-restraint can  
one forestall  
trouble.  
Forestalling  
trouble  
strengthens  
one's position.  
Such  
strengthened  
position enables  
one to withstand  
everything.  
Withstan

To get mankind to  
live in peace  
requires a full  
detachment  
Because only one  
who is detached  
knows how to live  
truthfully Letting go  
of everything  
before dying  
makes one live  
righteously One  
who lives  
righteously knows  
no trouble For one  
who knows no  
trouble, I

impossible, then  
there are no  
limits. Those  
without limits are  
capable of  
leading a  
country. Those  
with maternal  
leadership can  
long endure. This  
is to be deeply  
rooted in a firm  
foundation, the  
way of long life  
and eternal  
vision. up

ding everything,  
one remains  
unchallenged.  
Being  
unchallenged,  
one governs  
easily. Because  
he embodies  
Mother Nature  
within himself, he  
retains a sound  
position. This is  
the way to be  
deeply rooted  
and firmly based,  
And durable and  
long-lived. up

ife is unbounded  
One who is  
unbounded,  
considers the  
world as his home  
One who feels  
united with  
creation, lives  
happily ever after  
Then you'll be  
rooted again and  
you'll stand firmly  
Only like that will  
you live happily  
ever after and  
understand  
everything up

## Chapter 60

. Spirits Leading a large country is like cooking a small fish. When the world is led in accord with the Way, spirits lose their powers. It is not that they lose their powers

Whether governing a big country or cooking a little fish, follow Nature's way and no evil tendencies will get control. This does not mean that the dangers of evils can be elimin

Making sure that mankind lives in peace is a trifle Where righteousness is the main guide, delusions won't last Not that there will be no delusions at all But the people will be less sus

, but that their powers no longer harm people. Not only do the spirits not harm people, but the wise also do not harm people. Not harming each other, spiritual power grows. up

ated entirely, but only that they will cease to harm men. When ordinary men are unharmed, their leaders are unharmed. And when nobody harms anybody, perfect harmony prevails. up

ceptible to them Delusions damage people, and a wise man shows them it's so Therefore a wise man is a threat to delusion, But no threat for mankind Therefore they will become wise, too up

## Chapter 61

. Large and Small Countries A large country is like low land where rivers flow, a place where everything comes together, the female of all. The female overcomes the male with tranquillity. Tranquillity is underneath. A large country wins over a small country by placing itself below the small country. A small country

To be great, a state must be passively receptive, like the ocean which accepts whatever the rivers bring into it, or like the feminine which always submits to the masculine. Recall how the female always overcomes the male by means of her passivity. Passivity is submissiveness. Thus the great state places itself at the service of a small state before before i

When mankind lives in peace, There will be no superiors and inferiors It is like a big river, In which all side currents have come to rest The wildness comes to rest in peacefulness, Because it is c

wins over a large country by placing itself below the large country. Thus some win by placing themselves below, and others win by being below. A large country wants to protect people, and a small country wants to join and serve. Thus both get what they want. It is best for the large country to place itself below. up

t absorbs the small state. And a small state must serve the interests of the great state before it can be taken into the great state. Hence, some submit in order to take, while others submit in order to be taken. When a great state desires to have more people, and a small state desires to be protected, it is by submission that both obtain what they desire. up

alm and most lowly One who is the least by his disarming simplicity, Is therefore appealing to his fellow men And so it's a benefit for both of them So one who looks big, has to become small again up

## Chapter 62

The Way is Valued  
The Way is sacred  
to all things. It is  
treasure for the  
good and  
sanctuary for the  
bad. Fine words  
can buy honor.  
Good deeds can  
gain respect.  
Though there be  
bad people, why  
reject them?  
Therefore at the  
crowning of the  
emperor or at the  
installation of

Nature is  
profoundly worth  
while. It is that  
which is most  
worth while for  
good men, And it  
is the only real  
value for bad men.  
Flattery may gain  
favours, and gifts  
may help one to  
advance, But bad  
men know how to  
flatter and bribe.  
Therefore when  
leaders are  
installed in office,  
Better than he who  
artfully gives lavish  
gift

Everything inclines  
towards the  
original balance  
It's the bliss of true  
men It's a  
sanctuary for the  
untruthful But  
people flaunt  
themselves with  
flattery They only  
do nice things in  
exchange for  
gratitude  
Everybody does  
that so why  
shouldn't you?  
Therefore the  
people shout with  
joy when a new  
leader comes on  
the scene And

the three  
ministers, instead  
of sending gifts of  
jade and a team of  
four horses,  
remain still and  
send the Way.  
Why did the  
ancients prize this  
Way? Did they not  
say, "Seek, and  
you will find; let go,  
and you will be  
forgiven."  
Therefore the Way  
is valued by the  
world. up

s and glowing  
tribute, Is one who,  
by doing nothing  
but accepting his  
natural role as a  
follower, pays  
genuine homage.  
Why have men  
always valued  
Nature? Was it not  
because Nature  
submitted humbly  
to the task of  
benefiting the  
good and the bad  
alike? Is this not  
the reason why it  
is the most worth  
while thing in the  
world? up

let themselves be  
fooled by pomp  
and circumstance  
It's wise not to  
participate in this  
Do you know why  
the former wise  
people considered  
simplicity so  
important?  
Because they  
experienced that,  
one who seeks will  
find And that the  
truth sets one free  
from past and  
future Therefore  
simplicity is most  
important in this  
life up

## Chapter 63

. The Wise Never  
Strive Act without  
interfering. Work  
without doing.  
Taste the  
tasteless. Large or  
small, many or  
few, repay injury  
with goodness.  
Handle the difficult  
while it is still easy.  
Handle the big  
while it is still  
small. Difficult  
tasks begin with  
what is easy.  
Great acc

Act without  
intention Stop  
labouring Just  
enjoy life One who  
doesn't honour  
something small  
Isn't worthy of  
something big No  
more eye for an  
eye and tooth for a  
tooth Turn to them  
your other cheek  
Discover that what  
seems  
complicated is in  
fact very simple  
See the grandeur  
in what seems  
insignificant Don't  
turn simplicity into  
complexity Living  
purely i

omplishments  
begin with what is  
small. Therefore  
the wise never  
strive for the great  
and thus achieve  
greatness. Rash  
promises inspire  
little trust. Taking  
things too lightly  
results in much  
difficulty. Thus the  
wise always  
confront difficulties  
and therefore have  
no difficulty. up

s simple But  
people have made  
it complicated So  
one who's wise will  
never make  
trouble And  
therefore he can  
move mountains  
One who promises  
a lot is hardly ever  
trustworthy One  
with a lot of  
blinkers on will  
bring to pass lots  
of troubles But one  
who is wise looks  
before he leaps  
Therefore he won't  
start at all And  
because of that he  
knows no trouble  
up

## Chapter 64

himself and so he  
remains himself  
But people break  
down everything  
and they call it  
“progress” Once  
started, there is no  
end to A wise man  
strives for what  
others don't And  
takes to be  
important what  
others take to be  
unimportant He  
unlearns what  
other are still  
learning And turns  
back to a state of  
mind others have  
left Then he knows  
the way back to  
the source But  
realizes that the  
people do not want  
to hear about it up



## Chapter 65

Know the Eternal Standard The ancients who ruled skillfully did not try to enlighten people but kept them in the dark. People are hard to lead when they are too clever. Those who lead with cleverness rob the country. Those who lead w

Originally people knew how to follow Nature, For they did not try to arouse in the people an interest in cunning, but let them remained unspoiled. The shrewder people are, the harder they are to govern. Therefore to try to improve government by means of increasing cleverness in people is

The former sages, who travelled along the straight and simple path Brought the people wisdom instead of knowledge When people know much, unity is impossible to keep That's why science disturbs the togetherness of men And wisdom guards

ithout cleverness bless the country. Understanding these two is to know the eternal standard. Knowing the eternal standard is mystical power. Mystical power is deep and far-reaching, leading all things to return to perfect harmony. up

to endanger it. But to improve government by encouraging honesty in the people is beneficial. The comprehend the significance of these two ways is to be profoundly intelligent. Profound intelligence is that penetrating and pervading power To restore all things to their original harmony. up

that togetherness One who understands this Understands that wisdom and knowledge are in conflict with each other Once you understand this, you'll be wise And you will turn back to simplicity And feel one with everything and everybody up

## Chapter 66

. Leading from  
Behind Great  
rivers and seas  
are lords of all  
mountain streams,  
because they are  
good at staying  
below them.  
Therefore they are  
lords of the  
streams. Thus the  
wise in watching  
over the people  
speak humbly from  
below the people,  
and in leading th

Rivers and seas  
dominate the  
landscape,  
Because, by being  
good at seeking  
the lowest places,  
they fill and  
occupy and spread  
over everything.  
Likewise the  
intelligent man is  
superior to others,  
Because he  
admits that he is  
inferior, And he is  
a leader of others  
Because he is wil

Why are the  
seas and rivers  
the biggest  
among all  
waters? Because  
they are located  
on the lowest  
places Therefore  
they are the  
biggest So one  
who is wise  
among fools  
must be the least  
And ther

e people get  
behind them. In  
this way the wise  
watch over the  
people but do not  
oppress them;  
they lead the  
people but do not  
block them. Thus  
everyone happily  
goes along without  
getting tired.  
Because they do  
not compete, the  
world cannot  
compete with  
them. up

ling to be a  
follower. Thus  
although he is  
actually superior to  
others, they do not  
feel depressed.  
And when he  
leads them, they  
do not feel that  
they are being  
forced to obey. So  
all are happy to  
give him their  
support. Since he  
competes with no  
one, no one  
competes with  
him. up

efore he is the  
greatest But  
fools won't  
consider him as  
a threat They just  
don't understand  
him and take no  
notice of him  
Because he  
doesn't fight and  
argue with  
anybody, he is  
indisputable up

## Chapter 67

. Three Treasures  
Everyone says the  
Way is great and  
beyond  
comparison.  
Because it is  
great, it cannot be  
compared. If it  
were compared, it  
already would  
have seemed  
small. I have three  
treasures to be  
maintained and  
cherished: the first  
is love; the second  
is frugality; the  
third is not pushing  
oneself ahead of  
others. From

Everyone says:  
"Nature is great,  
yet Nature is  
simple." It is great  
because it is  
simple. If it were  
not simple, long  
ago it would have  
come to little.  
Nature sustains  
itself through three  
precious  
principles, which  
one does well to  
embrace and  
follow. These are  
gentleness,  
frugality and  
humility. When  
one is gentle, he  
has no fear of  
retaliation. When  
one is fruga

In life I am great,  
but to the world I  
am a failure In my  
grandeur, I am  
different from all  
the rest And that is  
exactly therefore  
the reason I am  
great If I would be  
like the rest, I  
would be just as  
unimportant and  
insignificant I have  
three treasures I  
cherish: The first is  
compassion The  
second is austerity  
The third is  
modesty Thanks to  
my compassion I  
can be brave  
Because I am  
austere I can be  
un

love comes  
courage; from  
frugality comes  
generosity; from  
not pushing  
oneself ahead of  
others comes  
leadership. Now  
courage without  
love, generosity  
without frugality,  
and leadership by  
pushing oneself  
ahead of others  
are fatal. For love  
wins all battles and  
is the strongest  
defense. Heaven  
gives love to save  
and protect. up

I, he has no fear of  
retaliation. When  
one is humble, no  
one challenges his  
leadership. When  
rudeness replaces  
gentleness, And  
extravagance  
replaces frugality,  
and pride replaces  
humility, The one  
is doomed. Since  
a gentle attack  
arouses little  
antagonism, And a  
gentle defense  
provokes little  
anger, Nature  
predisposes to  
gentleness those  
most suited for  
survival. up

## Chapter 68

. The Power of  
Not Striving The  
best soldier is  
not violent. The  
best fighter is not  
angry. The best  
winner is not  
contentious. The  
bes

The best soldier  
does not attack.  
The superior  
fighter succeeds  
without violence.  
The greatest  
conqueror wins  
without a  
struggle. The  
most successful  
manager leads  
wit

One who fights  
for peace is  
non-violent A  
true fighter is  
unshakeable A  
true victor does  
not argue A true  
leader is the  
least That's what  
people call  
“non-violent de

t employer is  
humble. This is  
known as the  
power of not  
striving, as ability  
in human  
relations, and as  
being in accord  
with heaven. up

hout dictating.  
This is called  
intelligent nonag  
gressiveness.  
This is called  
mastery of men.  
This is called  
matching the  
wisdom of the  
highest and  
oldest in Nature.  
up

fensibility” And  
that's how one  
gets the people  
on his side That  
is called “living  
according to your  
nature” That is  
the perfection of  
which the wise of  
old spoke up

## Chapter 69

. The Kind Win  
The strategists  
say, "Do not be  
the aggressor  
but the defender.  
Do not advance  
an inch, but  
retreat a foot  
instead." This is  
movement  
without moving,  
stretching the  
arm without  
showing it,  
confronting  
enemies with t

Military maxims  
say: "It is easier to  
defend than to  
attack." "It is better  
to back away a  
foot than to assault  
to gain an inch."  
This means that  
the best way to  
advance is to  
retreat. He who  
bares his flesh will  
appear to have no  
need for carrying  
weapons. He who  
does not flourish  
weapons appears  
to have not

One who  
understands that  
quarrels will  
never solve  
anything, Won't  
start them  
anymore and  
prefers to wait  
He rather takes a  
step back or  
retracts That's  
what people call  
winning by losing  
Showing strength  
without  
impressing Stand

he idea there is  
no enemy,  
holding in the  
hand no  
weapons. No  
disaster is  
greater than  
underestimating  
the enemy.  
Underestimating  
the enemy will  
destroy my  
treasures. Thus  
when the battle  
is joined, it is the  
kind who will win.  
up

hing to defend. He  
who does not  
prepare to defend  
himself appears to  
have no enemies.  
No one will attack  
a person unless he  
appears to be an  
enemy, For to  
attack one who is  
not an enemy is to  
lose a friend.  
Therefore, when  
opposing enemies  
meet for open  
battle, he who runs  
away to hide is the  
one who wins. up

ing firm without  
starting a fight  
Nothing is more  
disastrous than  
underestimating  
your enemy One  
who  
underestimates  
his enemy  
exposes oneself  
to danger  
Therefore he  
who's driven by  
compassion Is  
always the  
winner in a  
conflict up

## Chapter 70

. My Ideas Are  
Easy My ideas  
are easy to  
understand and  
easy to practice.  
Yet no one  
understands  
them or practices  
them. My ideas  
have a source;  
my actions have  
a master

The things I am  
saying are very  
easy to  
understand and  
very easy to  
practice. Yet no  
one in the world  
can comprehend  
them fully nor  
practice them  
perfectly. The  
things I am saying  
did not originate  
with me but have  
their source in  
Nature. It is  
because men do  
not

My words are  
easy to  
comprehend And  
easy to bring to  
practice Yet no  
one in the world  
wants to  
surrender to  
them And no one  
feels capable of  
living according  
to them My  
words have an  
origin, my way of  
living a principl

. Because people  
do not  
understand this,  
they do not know  
me. Since few  
know me, I am  
very precious.  
Therefore the  
wise wear coarse  
clothes and keep  
the jewel inside.  
up

understand this  
source that they  
do not understand  
me. Since those  
who understand  
me are few, they  
are, for that  
reason, all the  
more worthy of  
emulation.  
Therefore the  
intelligent man  
presents a poor  
exterior, yet  
carries Nature's  
riches embedded  
in his core. up

e But because  
the people do not  
dare to see this  
They are not  
able to  
understand me  
There are only a  
few who  
understand me  
and to them I am  
most precious  
One who is wise  
therefore acts  
unnoticed, but  
remains oneself  
up

## Chapter 71

. A Disease To  
know that you do  
not know is the  
best. To think  
you know when  
you do not is a  
disease.  
Recognizing this  
disease as a  
disease

To know how  
little one knows  
is to have  
genuine  
knowledge. Not  
to know how little  
one knows is to  
be deluded. Only  
he who knows  
when he is  
deluded can free  
himself from s

Realizing you  
can't know  
anything, is wise  
One who does  
not understand  
he can't know  
anything, is  
insane One who  
realizes his  
insanity,

is to be free of it.  
The wise are free  
of disease,  
because they  
recognize the  
disease as a  
disease.  
Therefore they  
are free of  
disease. up

uch delusion.  
The intelligent  
man is not  
deluded,  
because he  
knows and  
accepts his  
ignorance, and  
accepts his  
ignorance as  
ignorance, and  
thereby has  
genuine  
knowledge. up

Is able to get rid  
of it One who is  
wise is not  
insane anymore,  
Because he has  
disposed of his  
insanity  
Therefore he has  
a clear view up

## Chapter 72

. Do Not Suppress When people lack a sense of awe, then something awful will happen. Do not constrict people's living space. Do not suppress their livelihoods. If you do not harass them,

Do not be irritated when people do not recognize your importance; For if you are really important, sooner or later circumstances will force them to recognize it. Do not treat them contemptuously nor despise them; For only when you do not despise them will they not despise you. Al

When people have forgotten what to be afraid of, They will live in vague fear Why do they come to terms with this miserable way of living? Why don't they see the beauty of life? Why are they so s

they will not harass you. Therefore the wise know themselves but do not display themselves. They love themselves but do not exalt themselves. They let go of one and accept the other. up

though the intelligent man knows his own importance, He does not require that others recognize it; and he esteems himself for what he is, But does not insist that others esteem him. He does not seek to be esteemed by others because he recognizes his self-esteem as sufficient. up

cared of escaping their rut? One who is wise understands this, and won't flaunt it He enjoys it but doesn't consider it as his own merit He abandons his old way of living and embraces true life up



## Chapter 73

The Way of Heaven Those brave in killing will be killed. Those brave in not killing will live. Of these two, one is good, and one is harmful. Some are not favored by heaven. Who knows why? Even the wise consider it a difficult question. The Way of h

He whose courage expresses itself as defiance is often put to death. He whose courage manifests itself as patience to endure insult continues to live. Of these two kinds of courage, the one is beneficial, the other harmful. Many people are puzzled as to why, of two courageous men, one is harmed and one benefited. But the intelligent man finds no difficulty with this qu

Having guts and being reckless will lead to death. Having guts and being cautious saves life. The first is useless; the other useful. Only one who is wise understands the course of things. Therefore he won't intervene. It is easy to infringe upo

Heaven does not strive; yet it wins easily. It does not speak; yet it gets a good response. It does not demand; yet all needs are met. It is not anxious; yet it plans well. The net of heaven is vast; its meshes are wide, but nothing slips through. up

Question. Nature itself has the patience to endure insult, yet always wins in the end. It does not explain; nevertheless all understand. It does not command; but all eventually obey. It does not hurry; yet everything is accomplished. Nature's web is so finely woven - wide enough to catch the biggest, fine enough to catch the smallest - that not a single thing escapes. up

In the eternal laws of nature. But they always triumph. They don't speak, yet they do answer. They don't yell, yet everybody hears them. Like a net, the original order protects the Universe. Though its meshes seem wide, nothing can come through up

## Chapter 74

. Death People are not afraid to die. So why threaten them with death? If people were afraid of death, and lawbreakers could be caught and put to death, who would dare to do so? There is the Lo

It is futile to threaten people with death. If they are not afraid to die, they cannot be frightened by the death penalty; and if they are afraid to die, why should we kill them? Only Nature knows the proper time for a man to d

When people no longer fear death How can one threaten them with it? But if people are afraid of death and other people threaten to kill them When they infringe upon the law Well, who is still going to break the law? But there is only One who commands life

rd of Death who executes. Trying to do his job is like trying to cut wood for the Master Carpenter. Those who try to cut wood for the Master Carpenter rarely escape injuring their own hands. up

ie. To kill is to interrupt Nature's design for dying, Like a blundering apprentice judging himself to be wiser than his master. Whenever an apprentice thinks he is smarter than his master, he is very likely to hurt himself. up

and death Since people started to decide about life and death themselves They have actually taken a place on that One's chair Then they behave like sorcerer's apprentices Who assault the works of their master, With disastrous consequences for themselves up

## Chapter 75

Valuing Life  
People are hungry, because rulers eat too much tax-grain. That is why people are starving. People are hard to govern, because rulers interfere too much. That is why they are hard to

Those who make their living by collecting taxes cause the people to starve; when the people starve, the tax collectors, having no one to tax, starve also. Those who govern people make them discontented with being controlled; and therefore cause them to be un

People starve  
Because the wealthy enrich themselves off other people's backs That's why people starve  
People cannot be kept under control Because their leaders don't know what they're doing  
That'

govern. People do not care about death, because rulers demand too much of life. That is why they do not care about death. Only those who do not interfere with living are best at valuing life. up

controllable. Those who are so eager to make a better living that they risk death in doing so are the very ones most likely to die. Only the self-sufficient person who depends upon and endangers no one else in order to get his living is most sure to live. up

s why people cannot be kept under control  
People want to die Because they don't want to live this way  
Therefore people want to die Only the one who is not afraid to live, Is not afraid of dying up

## Chapter 76

. Life Is Tender  
When people are born, they are tender and supple. At death they are stiff and hard. All things, like plants and trees, are tender and pliant while alive. At death they are dried and withered. There

At birth a man is soft and weak - yet capable of living the whole life ahead of him. At death he is hard and tough - yet unable to live for even a minute longer. All things, whether plants of animals, while living, are soft and weak, But, when dead, are hard and tough. Thus hardness an

When a human being is born, it's supple and weak When it dies it's stiff and strong Everything that's alive (take a look at grass and trees for example) Is supple and flexible And when they die they are shriveled and parched Therefore hardness and inflexibi

fore the stiff and hard are companions of death. The tender and supple are companions of life. Thus strong arms do not win. A stiff tree will break. The hard and strong will fall. The tender and supple will rise. up

d toughness are allied with death, While softness and weakness are interrelated with life. This is the reason why the tougher fighters are more likely to be killed, and the harder trees more likely to be cut down. Therefore it is better to be soft and weak than to be hard and tough. up

lity are companions of death And suppleness and softness, companions of life That's why a rigid troublemaker will never win And an inflexible tree is doomed to death Inflexibility and power won't get you very far Suppleness and softness get you everywhere up

## Chapter 77

Taking and Giving  
The Way of heaven is like bending a bow. The high is lowered; the low is raised. The excessive is reduced; the deficient is increased. The Way of heaven takes from those who have too much and gives to those who do not have enough. The human way is different. It takes from

Nature's way is like the bending of a bow: The top which is high is lowered while the bottom which is low is raised, And the width which is narrow is widened while the length which is long is shortened. Nature's way is to take from those that have too much and give to those that have too little. Man's way, on the contrary, is to take away from those who have too little to give

The natural order is like stretching a bow The low bow gets pushed up high And the high tendon pulled downwards Where there is too much, it takes away Where there is not enough, it fills Nature strives for harmony all the time Decreases where there is too much And increases where there is too little But how opposite are the people i

those who do not have enough and gives to those who have too much. Who has more than enough to give to the world? Only the person of the Way. Therefore the wise act but do not rely on their own ability. They accomplish the task but claim no credit. They have no desire to seem superior. up

more to those who already have too much. What kind of man is able to take away from his own more than enough and give to others who have less than enough? Only he who embodies Nature's way within himself. Such a man gives his gift without desiring a reward, achieves benefit for others without expecting approbation, And is generous without calling attention to his generosity. up

n their behaviour The poor get poorer while the rich tend to get richer But one who is wise realizes that possession is burglary to community Therefore he disposes himself of that which belongs to the community So only one who is wise is detached He does what others ask him to, but nothing for himself Without taking credit for it up

## Chapter 78

. The Soft and Weak Nothing in the world is softer and weaker than water. Yet nothing is better at attacking the hard and strong. There is no substitute for it. The weak overcomes the strong; the soft overcomes the hard. Everyone knows this, but n

Nothing is weaker than water; Yet, for attacking what is hard and tough, Nothing surpasses it, nothing equals it. The principle, that what is weak overcomes what is strong, And what is yielding conquers what is resistant, Is known to everybody. Yet few men utilize it profitably in practice. But the intelligent m

Nothing in life is so soft and compliant as water Nothing is stronger in breaking what is hard and strong Nothing can exceed it in doing this Weak overcomes strong Soft overcomes hard Nobody knows this And no

o one puts it into practice. Therefore the wise say, "Those who bear the humiliation of the people are able to minister to them. Those who take upon themselves the sins of the society are able to lead the world." Words of truth seem paradoxical. up

an knows that: He who willingly takes the blame for disgrace to his community is considered a responsible person, And he who submissively accepts responsibility for the evils in his community naturally will be given enough authority for dealing with them. These principles, no matter how paradoxical, are sound. up

one practices it Therefore the sage says: One who is the least in the world, will be the greatest in life One who carries the sorrow of the world, is the greatest among mankind It sounds odd, but it's true up

## Chapter 79

. Stay with the Good  
Compromising with great hatred surely leaves some hatred. How can this be considered good? Therefore the wise keep their part of an agreement and d

Make agreements and then quarrelling when they are broken is never advisable. For even when a quarrel is patched up, some animosity will remain. How can this be considered good? Therefore the intelligent man continues to carry out his side of a bargain Even though he does not

When people make peace after violent hostility Then it's an armed peace How can it be right? One who is wise only takes a look at his own share in the conflict And never blames his opponent So

o not blame the other party. The good fulfill their obligations; the bad exact obligations from others. The Way of heaven is impartial. It always stays with the good. up

demand of others that they fulfill their promises The righteous insist on keeping agreements to the letter, And the indiscreet foolishly neglect or break their agreements; But Nature neither keeps nor breaks contracts (because it makes none). And its ways are good for men. up

one who is fair only faces his own part While one who is not daring enough to look at oneself, blames the other The road to self-knowledge knows no partiality But it does benefit the sincere up

## Chapter 80

. Home Is  
Comfortable In a  
small country with  
few people  
machines that can  
work ten or a  
hundred times  
faster are not  
needed. People  
who care about  
death do not travel  
far. Even if there  
are ships and  
carriages, no one  
takes them. Even  
if there are armor  
and weapons, no  
one display

May mankind live  
in freedom,  
equality and  
brotherhood again,  
So that there will  
be no need for  
leaders and  
superiors Then  
people won't fear  
death any longer  
And won't try to  
escape death May  
it be that people  
don't feel the need  
anymore, To move  
themselves about  
in vehicles And  
that they will have  
nothing to defend  
anymore May  
humankind  
abandon their  
instruments and  
machines, And  
enjo

s them. People  
return to knotted  
rope for records.  
Food is tasty;  
clothes are  
beautiful; home is  
comfortable;  
customs are  
delightful. Though  
neighboring  
communities see  
each other and  
hear each other's  
cocks crowing and  
dogs barking, they  
may grow old and  
die without going  
there. up

y the seeds of the  
fruit-bearing plants  
Those were meant  
as our food May  
they feel  
shamelessly proud  
of their natural  
beauty again May  
they stop locking  
themselves away  
in cities and  
houses, And start  
enjoying creation  
And if some fools  
still lock  
themselves away  
in nations,  
Civilizations, cities  
and houses May  
the wise men keep  
themselves far  
from this, And live  
happily ever after  
up



## Chapter 81

. True Words  
True words are  
not beautiful.  
Beautiful words  
are not truthful.  
The good do not  
argue. Those  
who argue are  
not good. Those  
who know are  
not scholarly.  
The scholarly do  
not know.

He who is genuine  
is not artificial; He  
who is artificial is  
not genuine. He  
who is intelligent is  
not quarrelsome;  
He who is  
quarrelsome is not  
intelligent. He who  
is wise is not  
pretentious; He  
who is pretentious  
is not wise.  
Therefore the  
intelligent man  
does not struggl

True words are  
not pretty Pretty  
words are not  
true Wise men  
do not talk about  
the Unspeakable  
One who talks  
about the  
Unspeakable is  
not wise Wise  
men are not  
learned And  
learned ones  
aren't wise A  
wise man doesn't  
gath

The wise do not  
hoard. The more  
they give to  
others, the more  
they have. The  
Way of heaven  
sharpens but  
does no harm.  
The Way of the  
wise  
accomplishes  
without striving.  
© Sanderson  
Beck, 1996

e to achieve for  
himself. The more  
useful he is to  
others, the more  
his needs will be  
cared for by those  
repeatedly  
benefited by his  
yielding. Nature's  
way is to produce  
good without evil.  
The intelligent  
man's way is to  
accept and follow  
Nature rather than  
to oppose Nature.

er possessions  
He gives what he  
has And  
therefore he is  
worthy of living  
He shares his  
wisdom with  
others His  
wisdom is  
never-ending  
Living according  
to nature never  
harms The life of  
a wise man is  
unselfish and  
peaceful